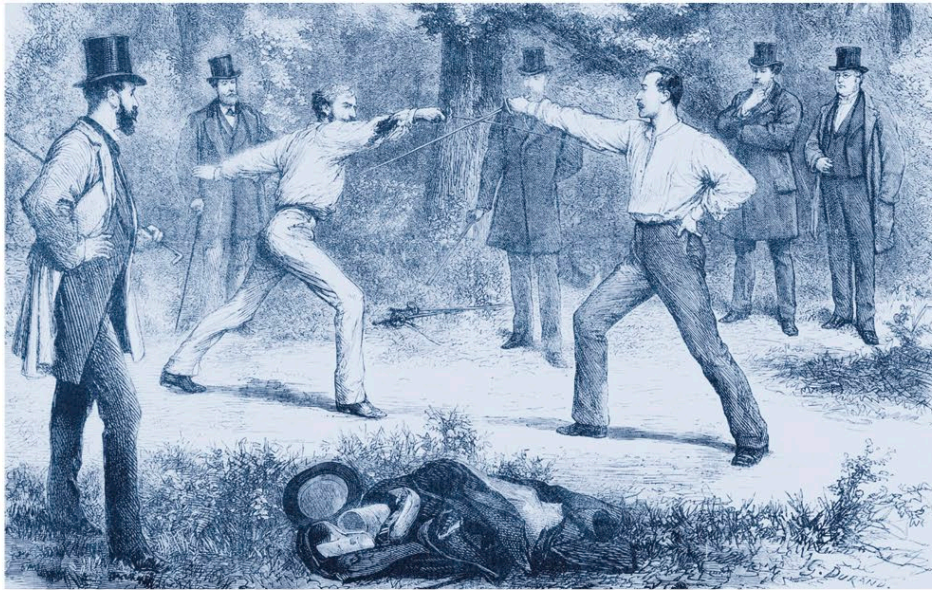


SYMBOLISM AND MYSTICISM

magic in turn-of-the-century France



▲ Parisian duel

This 1875 engraving depicts a duel over outraged honor. Journalist and “Notorious Satanist” Henri-Antoine Jules-Bois and Stanislas de Guaita fought a duel after Jules-Bois wrote a damning article about de Guaita. Neither was hurt as the pistols misfired; in a second duel between Jules-Bois and Papus, both men suffered minor saber wounds.

The occult revival that swept Western Europe after 1880 began in Paris at the same time as the French city emerged as the art capital of the world. Paris was a cultural melting pot of painters, musicians, poets, writers, magicians, and spiritualists—a collection of creative but argumentative individuals whose combined energies alternately synergized and caused clashes over competing ideas.

IN CONTEXT

Delving into satanism

J.K. Huysmans’ novel *Là-bas* (“Down There,” referring to Hell) bore fictionalized similarities to a real-life feud between Stanislas de Guaita and defrocked priest Joseph Boullan, in which each man accused the other of directing harmful magic at them. In the novel, the protagonist’s research into alchemy leads him into the satanic underbelly of 19th-century France. Rumor had it that Boullan had sacrificed his own child in a black mass, an episode described with gory relish in the book. One character in *Là-bas* says: “From exalted mysticism to raging Satanism is but a step.”

Huysmans’ controversial novel of 1891, *Là-bas*, explored Satanism.

A number of Parisian figures led the occult revival, absorbing existing beliefs, such as Rosicrucianism, the Kabbalah, and Freemasonry, as well as the ideas of the recent theosophical movement in the US (see pp.238–239). The French occult scholar and writer Eliphas Lévi was also a significant influence.

“Prince of the Rosicrucians”

Italian-born poet Stanislas de Guaita, dubbed “Prince of the Rosicrucians” for the breadth and depth of his occult learning, was the leading light. His home in Paris became a meeting point for like-minded people to discuss esoteric and mystical ideas. De Guaita launched the occult society l’Ordre Kabbalistique de la Rose-Croix in 1888—the same year that the Hermetic Order of the Golden Dawn was founded in London (see pp.242–243).

Two friends backed de Guaita’s initiative: Gérard Encausse (see p.257), a physician and occultist who worked under the name Papus and established Martinism (a form of Christian mysticism), and Joséphin Péladan, a fellow Martinist and writer who became increasingly controversial and egotistical. In contrast to the theosophists, who

